



LECTURE NOTES • LO 3.3

Guest Complaint Handling and Service Recovery

Topic	Focus
Why it matters	A complaint is feedback the hotel can still act on
Method	HEARD: hear, empathise, apologise, resolve, diagnose
Service recovery	Authority levels and compensation
Documentation	Complaint report and log

DURATION

90 minutes

FORMAT

Lecture and role play

MATERIALS

Slides, handout, rubric

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Handling the conversation



The HEARD method

- 1 **Hear:** let the guest finish; do not interrupt or defend.
- 2 **Empathise:** show that you understand how the guest feels.
- 3 **Apologise:** for the experience, sincerely, without blame.
- 4 **Resolve:** offer a fix within your authority, or escalate.
- 5 **Diagnose:** log the cause so it does not repeat.

SAY

“Thank you for telling me. I am sorry about the noise. Let me see what I can do for you now.”

AVOID

“That is not our fault.” “You should have told us earlier.” “That is the policy.”

Typical complaints and first responses

Situation	First response	Escalate when
Charge the guest did not make	Check the posting and the room report; correct the folio	It cannot be verified at the desk
Late check-out fee disputed	Show the policy from the booking confirmation	Guest asks for an exception
Noise or cleanliness	Apologise; check the complaint log	Compensation is requested
Long wait at check-out	Thank for patience; open a second desk	Guest may miss transport

Escalation ladder



Case study and rubric



CASE: DISPUTED MINIBAR CHARGE

Guest: I did not use the minibar. Remove the charge. I have a flight.

Receptionist: Thank you for telling me. I understand you are in a hurry. Let me check right now.

Receptionist: The report shows one item missing, but it may be a posting error. I will call housekeeping.

Result: Housekeeping confirms the item was in place. Charge removed; folio reprinted and signed. Cause logged: item posted to the wrong room.

Complaint dashboard • week 41

14

Received

12

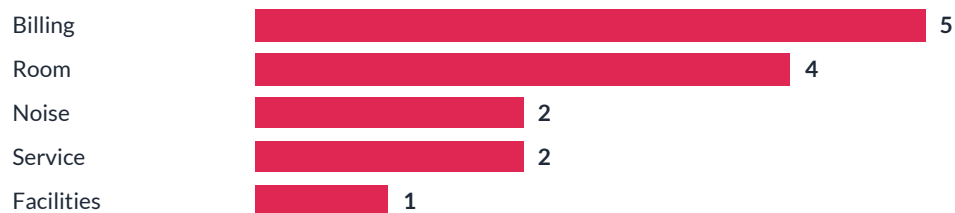
Resolved at desk

2

Escalated

9 min

Average resolution



Illustrative data. Billing is the largest category; check folios before check-out.

Assessment rubric

Criterion	Developing	Competent	Excellent
Listening	Interrupts	Listens fully	Summarises the problem back
Empathy and apology	Defensive	Apologises sincerely	Matches tone to the guest
Resolution	Unclear next step	Fix within authority	Fix plus follow-up
Documentation	Missing details	Complete report	Complete report and cause